Kitchen *& Kettle*

Apothecary Journal

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE — JUST A RECORD BOOK.

Learn how to make tea, salves, tinctures, and infused oils from the plants around you. Then write down what worked.

For the kitchen, not the clinic.

How to Use This Journal

This journal teaches you the basic methods — how to make a tea, a salve, a tincture, an infused oil. Then it gives you space to record your own experiments. No dosage charts, no medical claims. Just the techniques and a place to keep notes.

Start with what your family needs — not what a book tells you to make. Maybe someone has dry skin, maybe someone can't sleep, maybe you just want to replace store-bought teas with something from your own garden. The methods in this journal work for all of it.

Your Family's Needs

> *Start here. This is your context for everything else in the journal.*

FOR WHOM

WORKING ON

HONEST NOTE

This journal teaches kitchen methods — how to extract, infuse, and preserve. It does not tell you what to take for a headache. Plants are powerful. Respect that. If you're pregnant, nursing, on medication, or uncertain about a plant, ask someone who studied this longer than a blog post.

Herb Journal

> *One page per herb you're getting to know. What it does, how you've used it, what you've noticed.*

HERB #1

HERB

DATE

HERB #2

HERB

DATE

HERB #3

HERB

DATE

Herb Journal (cont.)

HERB #4

HERB

DATE

HERB #5

HERB

DATE

HERB #6

HERB

DATE

HERB #7

HERB

DATE

HERB #8

HERB

DATE

Herb Inventory

> *What's in your cupboard. Update when you use something or bring something new home.*

HERB	FORM	QTY	SOURCE	ACQUIRED	NOTES

Harvest Logs

> *What you picked, when, and where. Build a year-over-year record.*

DATE	HERB	LOCATION	PART	QTY	NOTES

Making Tea

The simplest way to work with herbs. Hot water pulls out water-soluble compounds — volatile oils, bitter principles, mucilage. Most herbs give up what's useful in 10–15 minutes of steeping.

Hot infusion (leaves and flowers): Pour just-boiled water over 1–2 teaspoons of dried herb per cup. Cover — the volatile oils escape with the steam. Steep 10–15 minutes. Strain. Drink warm. For fresh herbs, use about triple the amount — they're mostly water weight.

Cold infusion (mucilaginous herbs like marshmallow root): Cover the herb with cold water, leave on the counter 4–8 hours or overnight. Strain. This pulls out the soothing, slippery compounds that heat can destroy.

> *Taste your tea before adding honey. Some herbs are surprisingly sweet on their own. Some are bitter on purpose — that bitterness is medicine.*

TEA JOURNAL

BLEND #1

NAME

DATE

INGREDIENTS

BLEND #2

NAME

DATE

INGREDIENTS

Tea Blends

> *Record every blend you try. You'll thank yourself when you nail one and want to make it again.*

BLEND #3

NAME

DATE

INGREDIENTS

BLEND #4

NAME

DATE

INGREDIENTS

BLEND #5

NAME

DATE

INGREDIENTS

BLEND #6

NAME

DATE

INGREDIENTS

Making Salves

A salve is an infused oil thickened with beeswax. It stays solid at room temperature and melts on contact with skin. Salves carry the oil-soluble properties of herbs — the stuff that doesn't come out in water.

Step 1: Make an infused oil. Cover dried herb with a carrier oil — olive oil is the standard, but jojoba, sweet almond, or sunflower all work. Use dried herbs; fresh herbs carry water that can make the oil go rancid. Let it sit in a warm spot for 2–4 weeks, shaking the jar when you remember. Or use the quick method: place the jar in a pot of warm water (not boiling) for 2–4 hours. Strain through cheesecloth.

Step 2: Add beeswax. For every cup of infused oil, use about 2 tablespoons of beeswax pastilles (or grated beeswax). Melt together in a double boiler or a glass jar set in a pot of water. Stir. To test the consistency, drip a few drops onto a cold plate — it'll set in seconds. Too soft? Add more wax. Too hard? Add more oil.

Step 3: Pour and set. Pour into tins or small glass jars while still warm. Let cool undisturbed. Label immediately — you will forget what's in it. Salves keep about a year in a cool, dark place.

> *Calendula, plantain, comfrey, and yarrow are classic salve herbs. Start with one herb before you start blending. That way you know what each one does for your skin.*

SALVE #1

NAME

DATE

OIL & HERB

Salve Recipes

Record every batch. What you infused, how long, and how it turned out.

SALVE #2

NAME

DATE

OIL & HERB

SALVE #3

NAME

DATE

OIL & HERB

SALVE #4

NAME

DATE

OIL & HERB

SALVE #5

NAME

DATE

OIL & HERB

Making Tinctures

A tincture is an herb extracted in alcohol. Alcohol pulls out a wider range of compounds than water — resins, alkaloids, and essential oils that tea leaves behind. A well-made tincture keeps for years.

The folk method (no math required): Fill a jar about halfway with dried herb (or loosely packed fresh herb — don't cram it). Cover completely with alcohol — 80-proof vodka is the standard because it's half water and half ethanol, which together extract both water-soluble and alcohol-soluble compounds. Brandy works too and tastes better. Leave at least an inch of alcohol above the herb. Seal tightly.

Wait. Put the jar somewhere you'll see it — a kitchen shelf, not a dark cupboard you'll forget about. Shake it when you think of it. Wait 4–6 weeks minimum. Longer is fine; tinctures are patient.

Strain and bottle. Pour through cheesecloth or a fine mesh strainer. Squeeze the herb to get the last of the liquid out — that's the strongest part. Pour into a dark glass dropper bottle if you have one; a clean jar works too. Label with the herb, date, and alcohol used.

> *Start your first tincture with something familiar — chamomile, lemon balm, or ginger. Something you already know you like.*

TINCTURE #1

HERB	
ALCOHOL	
STARTED	
DECANTED	

Tincture Records

Herb, alcohol, dates. The details you'll want six months from now.

TINCTURE #2

HERB

ALCOHOL

STARTED

DECANTED

TINCTURE #3

HERB

ALCOHOL

STARTED

DECANTED

TINCTURE #4

HERB

ALCOHOL

STARTED

DECANTED

Making Infused Oils

An infused oil is the foundation of salves, massage oils, and balms. It's also useful on its own — as a bath oil, a moisturizer, or a base for a few drops of essential oil.

Cold infusion (best for delicate flowers): Fill a clean jar halfway with dried herb. Cover with oil — olive, jojoba, sunflower, or sweet almond. Seal. Place in a sunny windowsill for 2–4 weeks. The sun warms the oil gently and helps the extraction. Shake when you remember. Strain. The oil takes on the color and scent of the herb.

Warm infusion (faster, better for roots and barks): Place the herb and oil in a glass jar. Set the jar in a pot of water on the lowest heat — you want it warm, not simmering. A slow cooker on \"warm\" works beautifully. Leave 2–4 hours. Strain. Don't let the water boil — high heat can destroy the compounds you're trying to extract.

> *Dried herbs only. Fresh herbs contain water, and water in oil creates an environment where bacteria can grow. Your infused oil should be clear when you strain it. If it's cloudy, it probably had moisture in it — use it quickly or toss it.*

INFUSED OIL #1

HERB

OIL

METHOD

INFUSED OIL #2

HERB

OIL

METHOD

Drying & Storing Herbs

The gap between harvest and jar is where most herbs are ruined. Heat, light, moisture, and time are the enemies. Get the drying right and your herbs keep for a year.

When to harvest: Leaves are strongest just before the plant flowers. Flowers are best picked the day they open, in the morning after the dew dries. Roots are dug in fall or early spring when the plant's energy is stored underground. If you're not sure, harvest on a dry, sunny morning — that's rarely wrong.

How to dry: Tie small bundles and hang them upside down in a warm, airy place — not in direct sun. An attic, a porch, a well-ventilated room. If you're in a humid climate, use a dehydrator on the lowest setting or spread the herbs on a screen with a fan blowing across them. Herbs are dry when they crumble easily between your fingers — stems should snap, not bend.

How to store: Glass jars in a dark cupboard. Not plastic bags — plastic breathes. Not above the stove — heat and steam degrade herbs fast. Label with the herb and the date you dried it. Whole herbs keep their potency longer than crushed ones; crush them just before using.

> *If you open a jar and it smells like nothing, the volatile oils have evaporated. The herb isn't spoiled — it's just weak. Use more of it or compost it and start fresh.*

DRYING LOG

HERB	
HARVESTED	
METHOD	
YIELD	

Drying Records

> *Track each batch. You'll know what dried well and what didn't.*

HERB	STARTED	METHOD	FINISHED	YIELD	NOTES

Notes

For whatever doesn't fit a category. Plants you want to try, books to read, questions to research.

NOTES

NOTES

NOTES

NOTES

Learn the method, then teach yourself

You don't need a degree to make a cup of tea. You don't need a license to infuse oil. The plants don't ask for credentials — they just grow. Pay attention, keep notes, and trust your senses. The best apothecary is the one who wrote things down.

Not medical advice. Just a record book.

Works because it works.